

Home ground, world stakes

For the first time in **17 years**, the badminton world will gather in India for the World Championships. Delhi will provide the stage; for India's leading players, it is an opportunity to turn home support, and some difficult draws, into medals.

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The last major badminton tournament staged at New Delhi's Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium ended with an image no sport would want associated with itself. At the India Open held in January, the game became somewhat of a sideshow. Animals wandered around the seating galleries, and bird droppings fell on the court in the middle of matches. Players complained about the cold and the poor air quality. Conversations about the tournament shifted more towards the venue, cleanliness, and hygiene than the

badminton being played.

The BWF (Badminton World Federation) World Championships, beginning at the same venue on August 17, will offer India a chance to erase memories of that fiasco. The World Championships are one of the sport's biggest events and, returning to India for the first time in 17 years, will inevitably attract scrutiny on the host. Organisers have said they are looking to ensure there are fewer issues this time. A triple-door entry system has been installed, seating has been improved, and an international firm has been brought

in to provide better overhead lighting. With the competition being held in August, the weather and air quality, too, should not be a problem.

The hope is that once the first shuttle goes up, the focus will be on the court.

Tough draws

There is P.V. Sindhu, chasing a sixth World Championships medal. India's greatest men's doubles pair, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, is chasing the world title that has so far eluded it. Lakshya Sen will be trying to rediscover the form that

Still got it: P.V. Sindhu recently became the first Indian — and, at 31, the oldest woman — to win a BWF Super 750 title, beating world No. 3 Akane Yamaguchi 21-17, 21-17 in the Japan Open final.

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